

Beyond the Numbers: Decolonizing Learning Outcomes And Reclaiming Educational Outcomes for Peace in African Schooling

Nene Onyedi Ibezim | Penn GSE Capstone Showcase 2026 | University of Pennsylvania

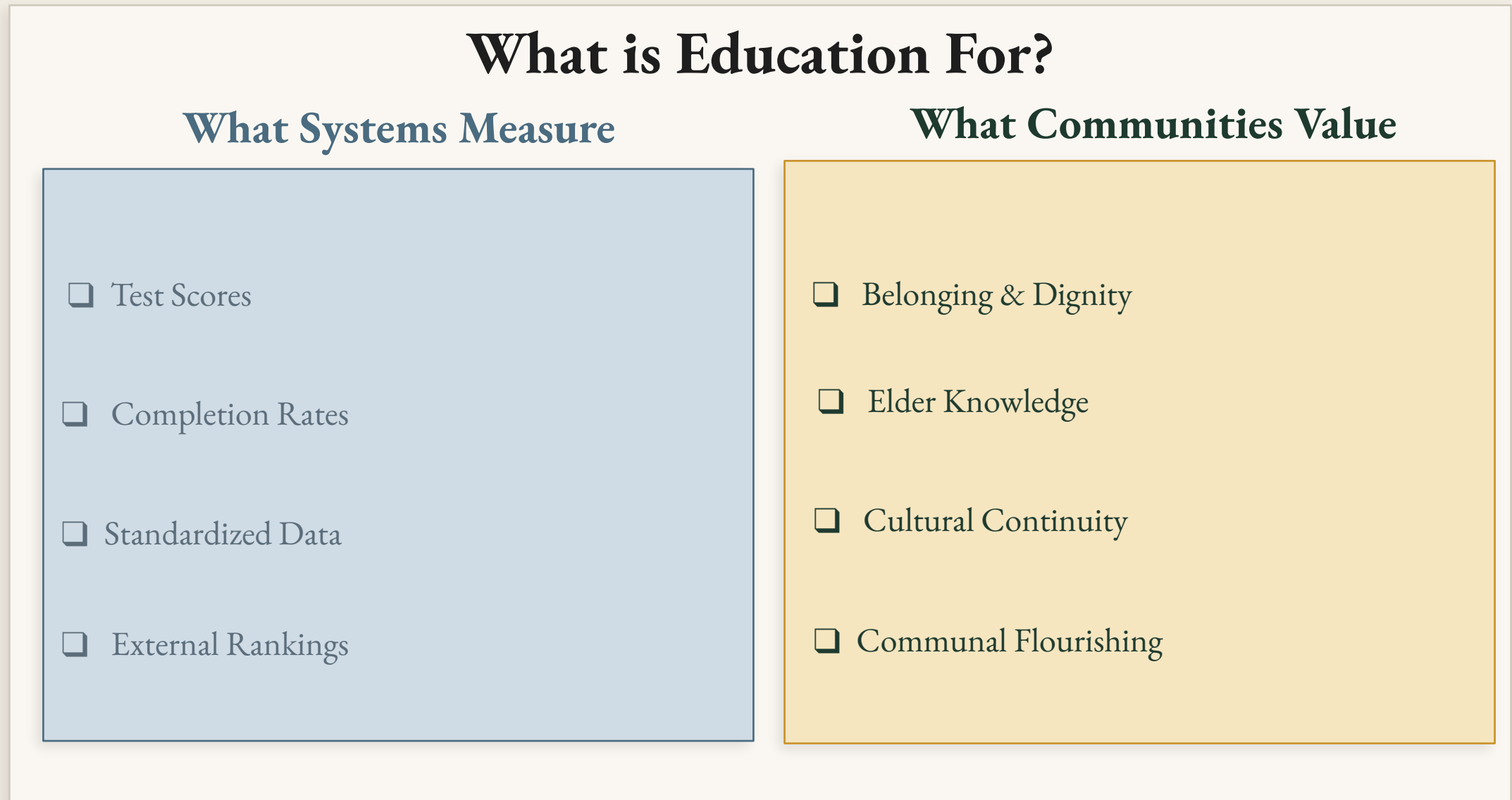


THE PROBLEM

1. Why This Matters

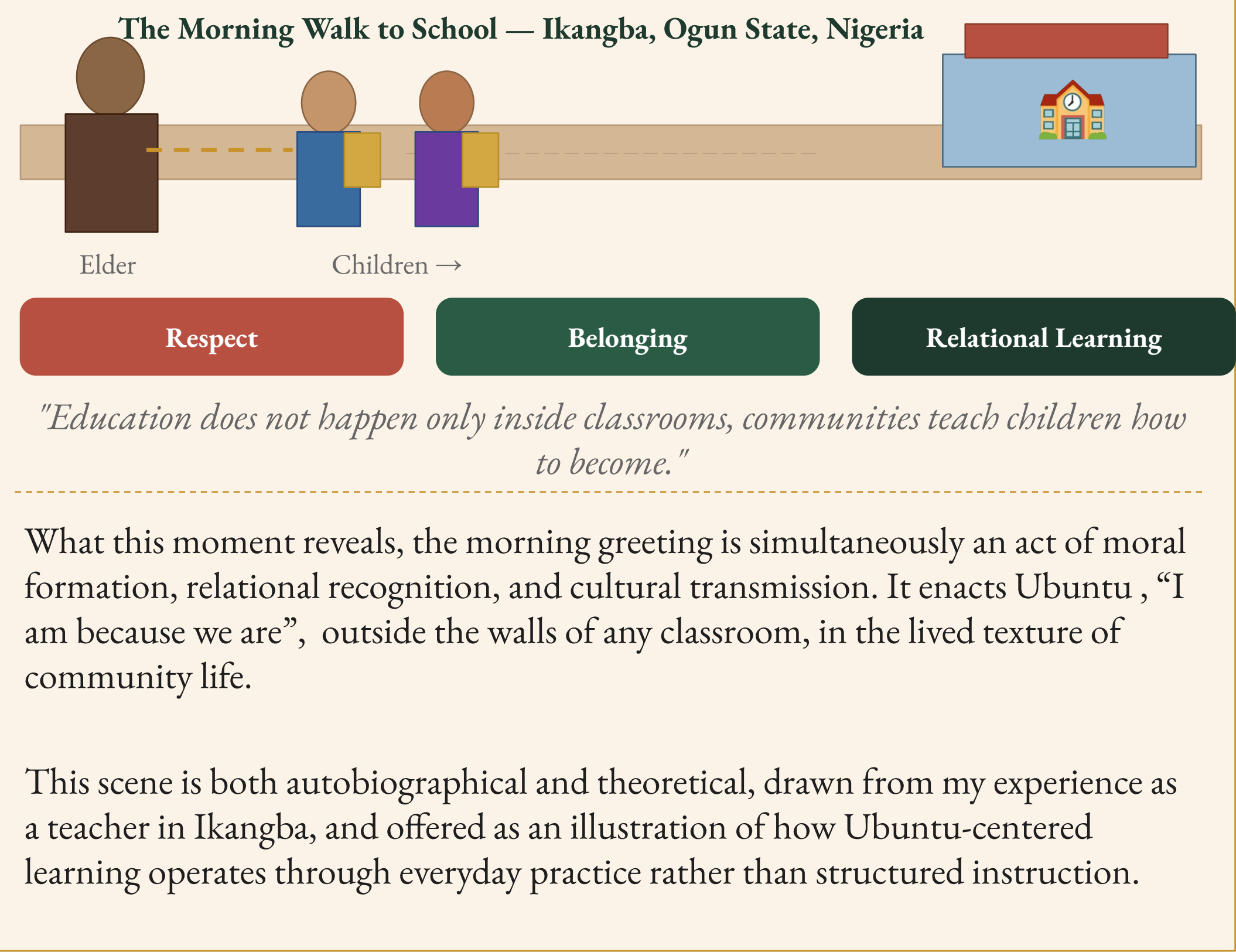
Across Africa, education quality is increasingly judged through test scores, completion rates, and standardized indicators shaped by global policy agendas. These frameworks promise accountability, but they narrow the meaning of education , treating learners mainly as units of performance.

This paper argues that such frameworks overlook what many African communities have long understood as central to education: dignity, belonging, moral formation, cultural continuity, and the ability to live well with others. When schools are valued only for what can be counted, important forms of learning disappear from view.



2. A Story from Ikangba

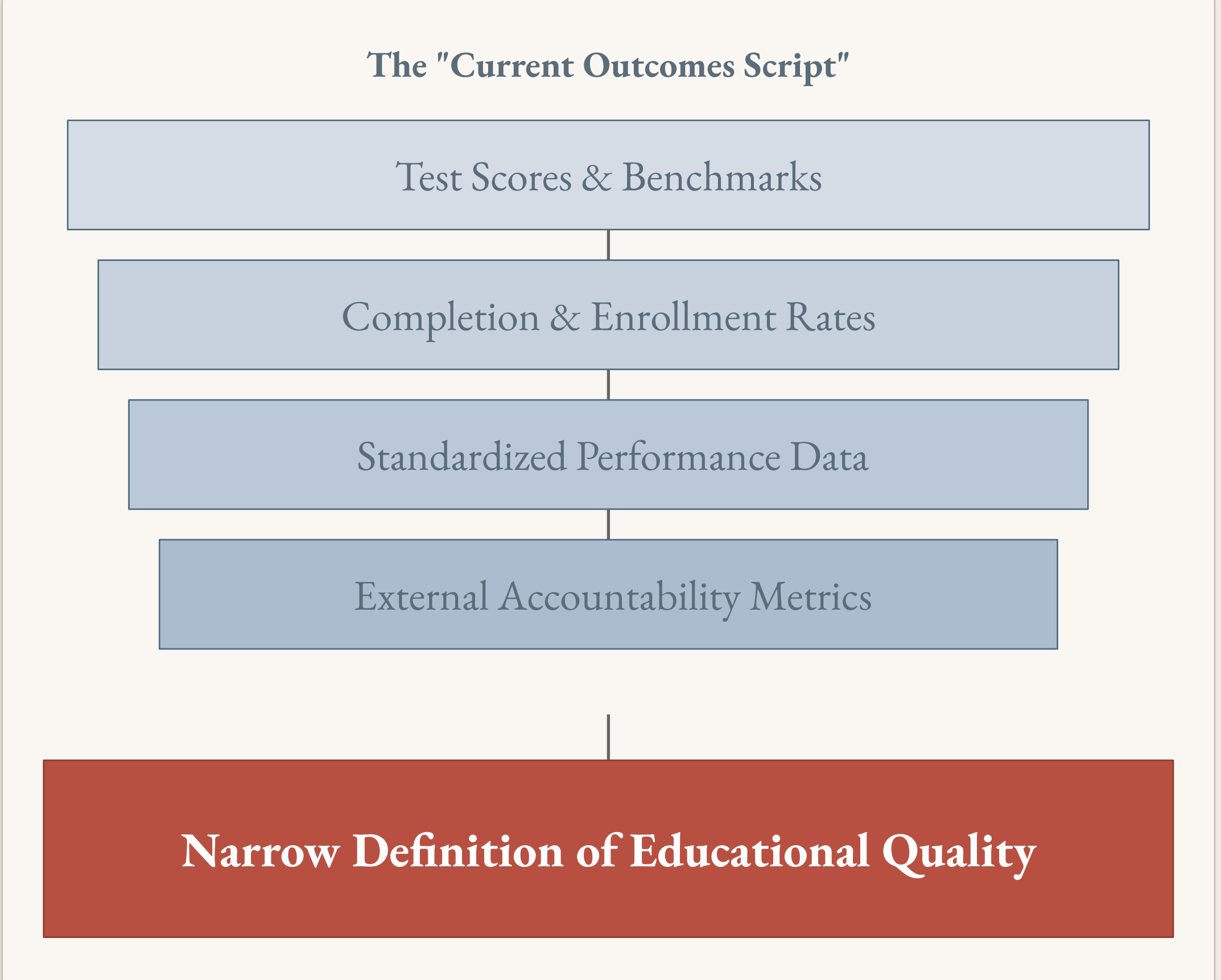
In Ikangba, Ogun State, Nigeria, children walking to school often pause to greet elders along the road. No exam records this. No curriculum mandates it. Yet this act teaches respect, belonging, obligation, and relational identity , core dimensions of Ubuntu-centered learning. Education does not happen only inside classrooms. Communities also teach children how to live with others, how to honour relationships, and how to grow into persons of good character. The morning walk is itself a curriculum.



3. What Counts Now

Current education systems define quality through standardized test performance, literacy and numeracy benchmarks, completion rates, and externally defined accountability measures.

These indicators create a narrow image of success, privileging what is easily tested and ranked across contexts while sidelining local understandings of what education is for. As a result, schooling becomes increasingly shaped by performance logic rather than community-defined human development.

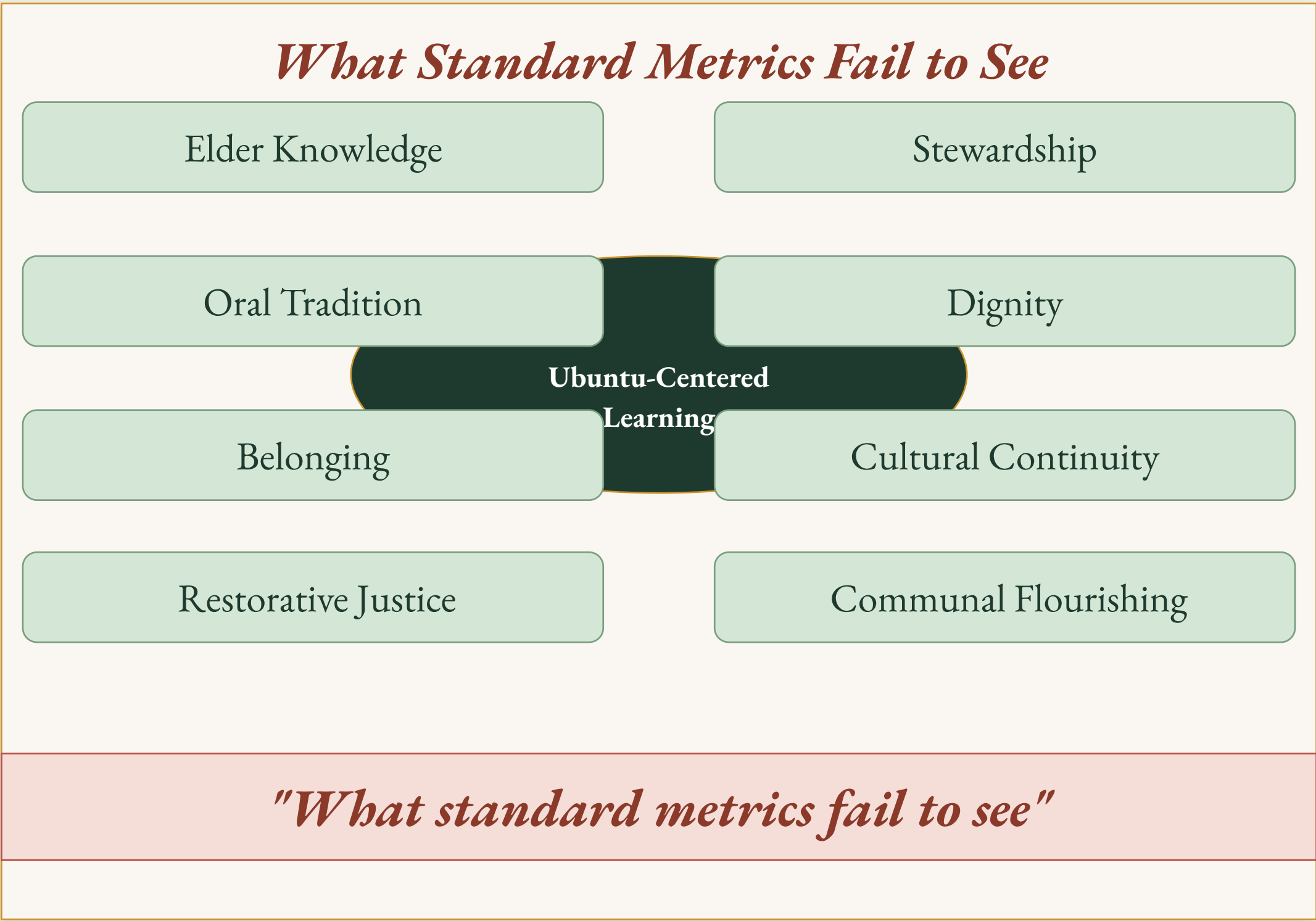


THE THEORY

4. What Current Systems Miss

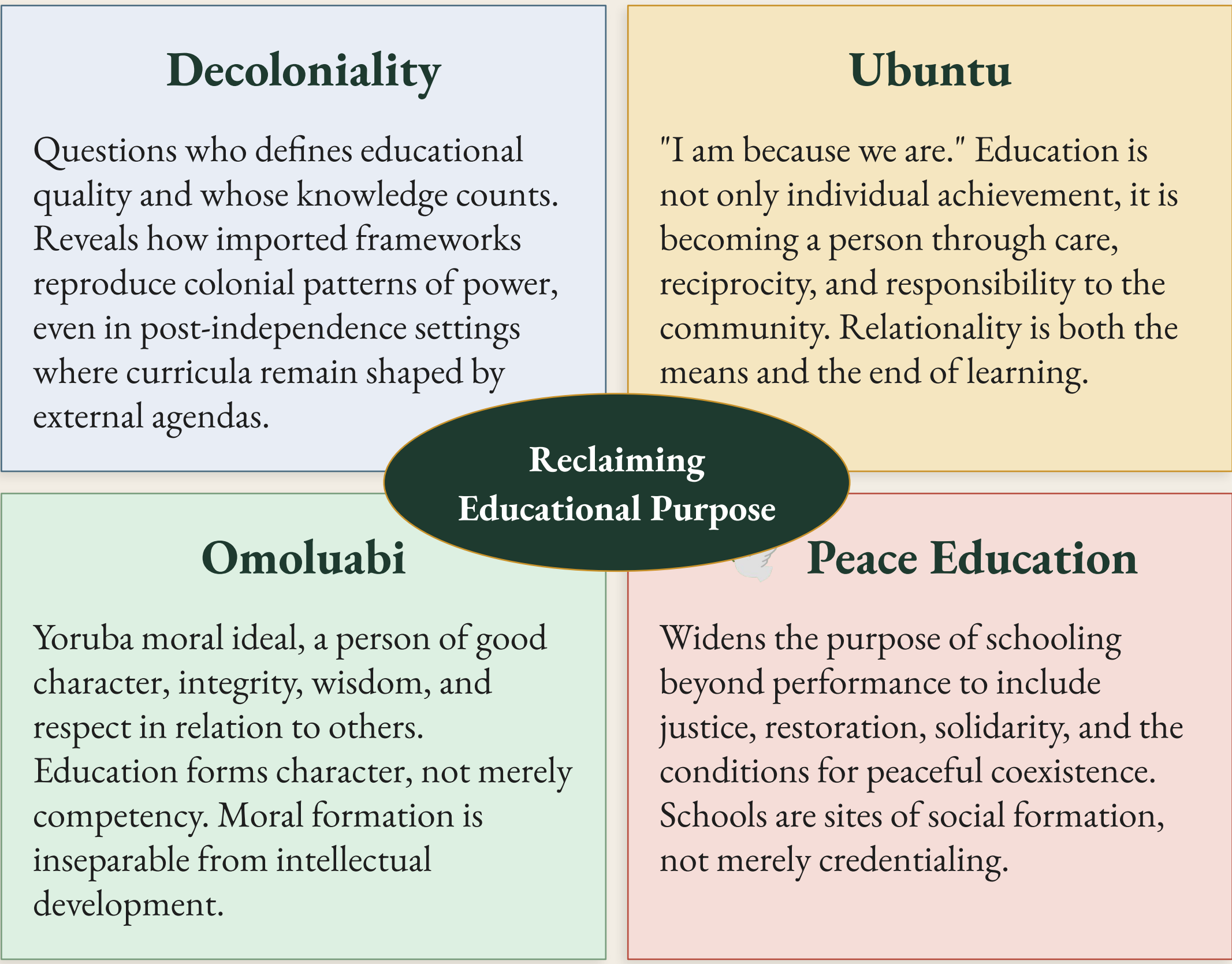
When educational quality is reduced to measurable outcomes, several important forms of learning become invisible. These include dignity, belonging, cultural continuity, elder knowledge, oral tradition, restorative justice, land stewardship, and communal flourishing.

What is missed is not marginal, it is central to how many African communities understand education. These are the relational, moral, and communal foundations through which people learn how to live responsibly with others. When communities are not permitted to define what counts as meaningful learning, schooling can inadvertently disconnect children from their identities and inherited knowledge systems.



5. Conceptual Lens

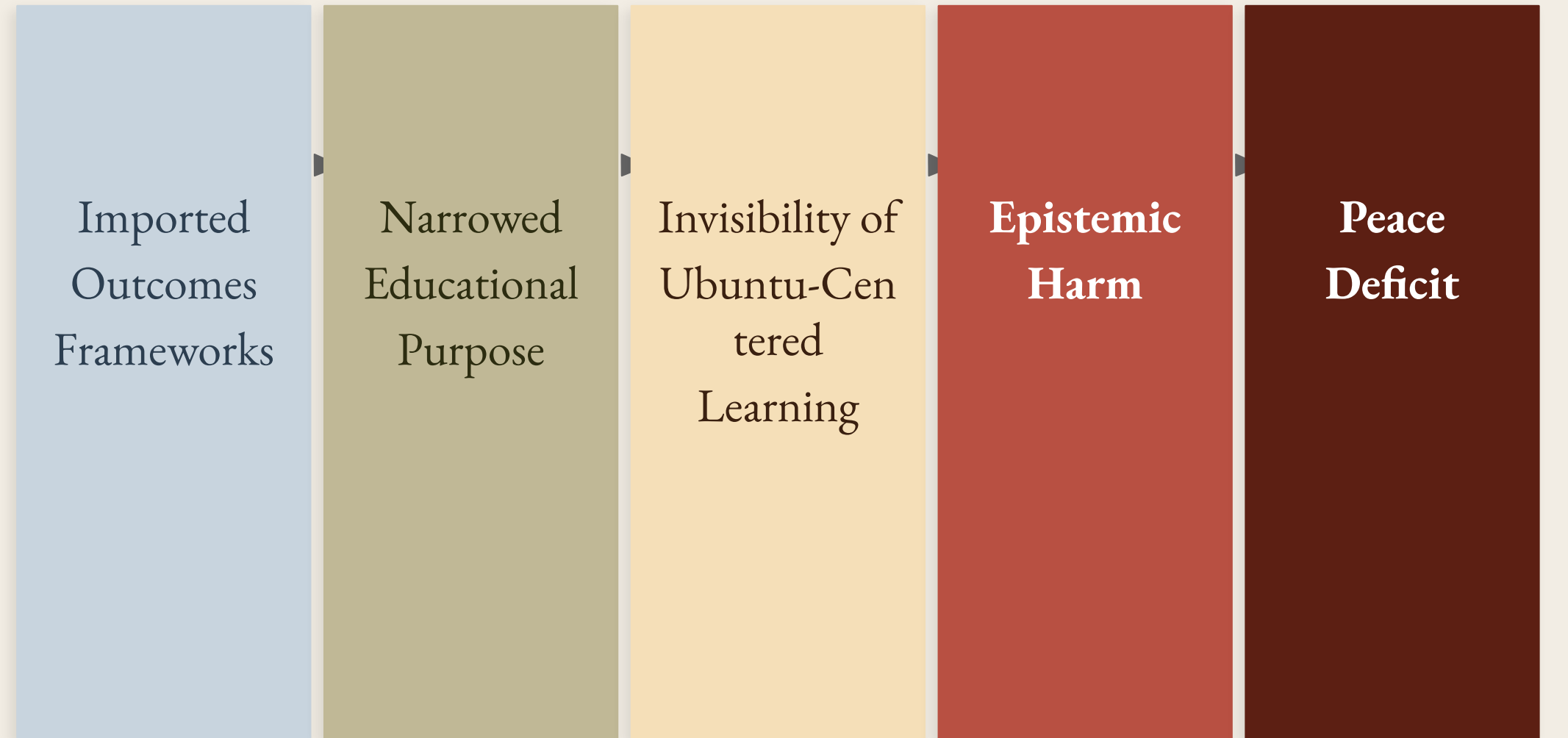
This paper draws on four interconnected theoretical pillars to challenge and reimagine educational purpose. Each pillar illuminates a different dimension of what education can and should accomplish in African contexts:



6. Main Insight: Epistemic Harm

This paper argues that imported outcome-based frameworks can produce epistemic harm. This happens when external systems define educational value so narrowly that African ways of knowing, teaching, and forming persons are treated as invisible or secondary.

This is more than a technical problem of assessment design. It is a problem of recognition and power. When communities are not allowed to define what counts as meaningful learning, schooling can disconnect children from their identities, relationships, and inherited knowledge systems, creating a deficit of belonging and peace.

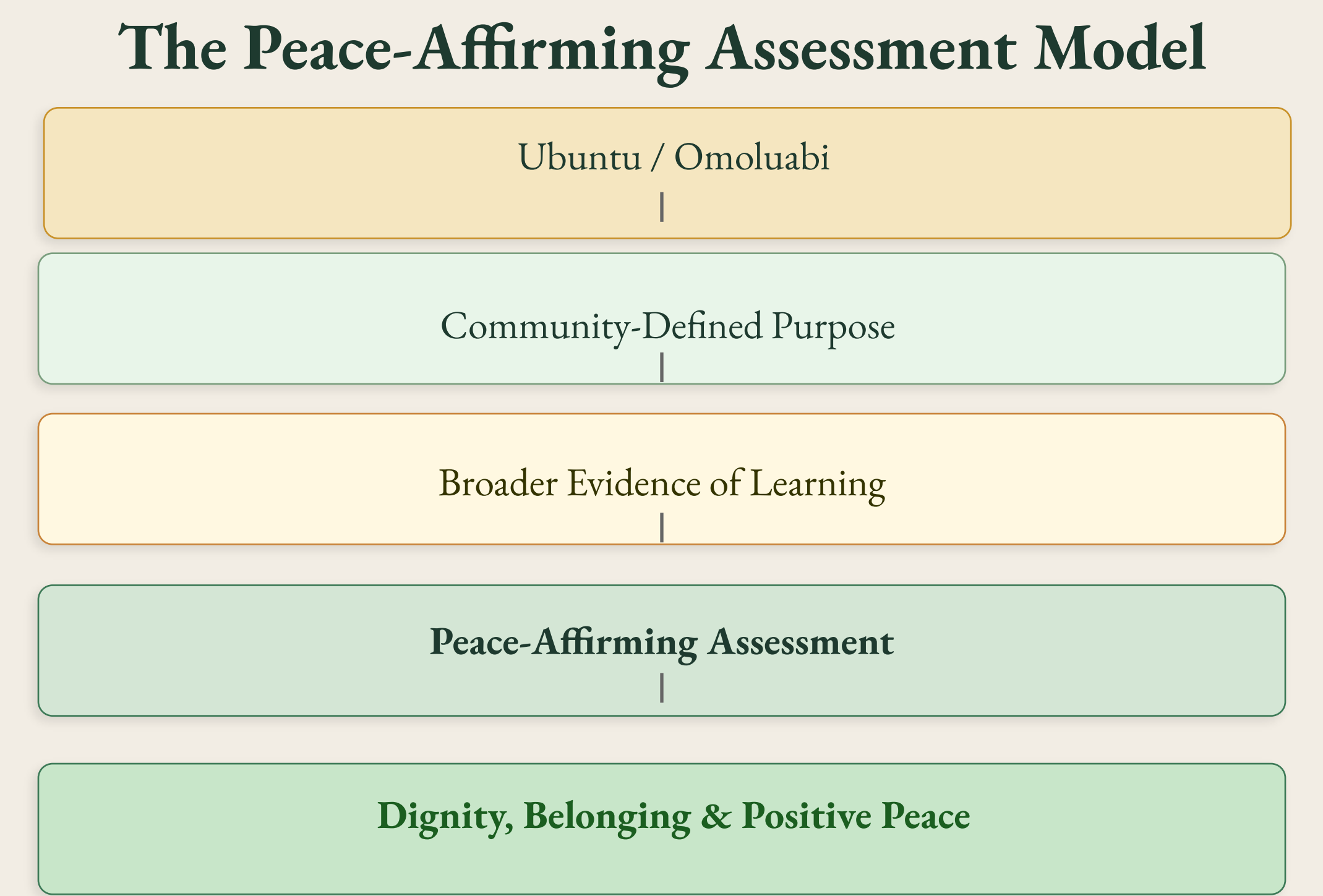


THE ALTERNATIVE

7. A Constructive Alternative

This paper proposes peace-affirming assessment as an alternative framework for accountability. It does not reject accountability. It widens it by asking different questions: What kind of person is the learner becoming? What kind of community is the school helping sustain?

Peace-affirming assessment centers community-defined educational purposes, combines qualitative and quantitative evidence, and values empathy, responsibility, collaboration, stewardship, and restorative engagement alongside academic learning. It treats assessment as an act of recognition, not merely measurement.



8. What Counts vs. What Should Count

What Counts Now	What Should Count
☐ Test Scores	✓ Dignity
☐ Completion Rates	✓ Belonging
☐ Rankings	✓ Empathy
☐ Standardization	✓ Cultural Continuity
☐ Performance Logic	✓ Communal Flourishing
☐ External Success	✓ Restorative Capacity

9. Why It Matters for Policy & Peace

If schools value only what can be standardized, they risk producing technically competent learners while neglecting the relationships, values, and social capacities that sustain peaceful communities.

A broader understanding of educational quality encourages community participation in defining success, recognition of local knowledge systems, and assessment designs that support justice, restoration, and belonging.

It matters for peace because positive peace requires more than the absence of conflict, it demands solidarity, mutual recognition, responsibility, and communal well-being. Schools are not separate from the societies they serve; they help form the moral fabric of those societies.



Key References

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